



WHY LASER?

The dream of the paperless office is still a dream, and printing is still very much of a critical function for the whole gamut of PC users—home users, small offices and corporates. Whether it's printing business reports or presentations for your boss or clients, marketing material for your sales people, bills for customers, or photos to share with your non-wired friends—computer-generated printouts are everywhere. Usage patterns, and therefore, the type of printer required for different kinds of user are different. We analyse where the laser printer fits in.

For any printing requirement, you'd generally consider three types of printer—dot-matrix, inkjet and laser. There are three broad parameters to be considered with each—print quality, costs, and print volumes and printing speed.

Quality: Dot-matrix printers are severely limited in terms of print quality. Inkjets are suited for images as well as graphics, while laser printers provide crisp text printouts.

Cost: There are two cost factors to be considered when purchasing

a printer: the upfront purchase cost, and the operational costs in terms of cost per page (cpp). You can buy an inkjet printer for as low as Rs 2,600, an 80-column dot-matrix for about Rs 7,000, and an entry-level mono laser for Rs 10,000. However, in terms of operational costs, inkjet printers are the most expensive, with an average cpp of Rs 2. Dot-matrix printouts are the cheapest with a cpp of just about Rs 0.15, while lasers hover around Re 1 per page.

Volume and speed: At about six to seven pages a minute, inkjets are slow, and not suited for high-volume printing, especially when you consider the high cpp. Moreover, the print head tends to heat up, leading to ink leakage if you're doing high-volume printing. But both dot-matrix and lasers are suitable for high volumes. The duty cycle for entry-level lasers can be about 5,000 pages per month, and you can get around 15 pages a minute.

Considering these factors, laser printers are ideally suited for small-office and corporate environments where print volumes are higher, and it's primarily text that's printed.

Entry-level Monochrome Laser Printers

Ever since the prices of laser printers came down to the level of affordability of small and medium businesses, it's made more sense to go for a laser printer rather than a dot matrix or an inkjet. There are several reasons for this, primarily speed and quality. Lasers are fast compared to the average inkjet, and much faster than dot matrix printers. That's why a laser makes a very good choice in environments where one printer is shared amongst five to ten users. Entry-level laser printers are generally capable of printing around 12-16 pages per minute (ppm). This speed is

good enough for SoHo environments, where printing is not a continuously-performed task, as in large organisations. Even in a kind of setup where continuous printing is done, the laser printer comes in; inkjets start leaking after being used for several hours at a stretch.

Mono lasers are the best choice where documents primarily contain text. Laser printers are also the printer of choice for small DTP houses which see lots of customers every day for various printing needs. Here, most customers come for prints that are later used for making screens for screen printing. Inkjets and dot

matrix printers are useless here, because both are ink-based, and light passes through the prints. Laser printers create fonts and graphics by depositing solid toner on solid paper. Similarly, inkjets and dot matrix printers are useless in transparency printing, because ink does not dry easily on transparencies.

Laser printouts generally show no smudging, and graphics, too, are crisp. Mono lasers are also capable of producing excellent shades of grey, which makes even combination documents look lively. And lasers are quieter compared to dot matrix printers.



You Need	A printer that can give you good printing speeds and better quality than an inkjet printer. Should have low running cost and should be compact	A one-stop solution for printing, scanning and copying at a reasonable speed, provides good quality, and incurs low running costs.	A printing solution that can print at laser speeds and be capable of high print volumes, while being able to print colour printouts at inkjet-like quality
Look For	A monochrome laser printer that has at least 128 MB of buffer memory, offers networking features, and can fire out a minimum of 15 pages per minute	A laser MFD that'll give good printing speeds, be able to scan at high resolutions, and have a toner life of around 3,000 pages	Most entry-level colour laser printers will meet these requirements
Our Pick	HP LaserJet 1015; Canon LBP3200	Xerox PE16; Samsung SCX4216F	HP LaserJet 1500L; Canon LBP2410
Price	Up to Rs 15,000	Up to Rs 45,000	Rs 45,000 upwards

